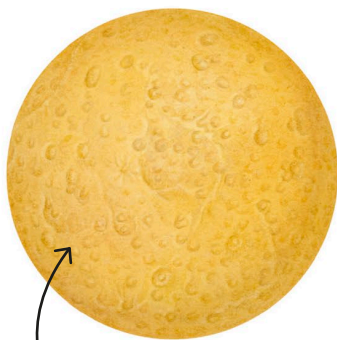




Battered planet

Mercury is covered with bowl-shaped hollows called craters. Mercury's craters were formed millions of years ago when asteroids crashed into it. It is not easy to spot Mercury in the sky because it stays close to the Sun. You may sometimes see it near the horizon—where the Earth meets the sky—at sunrise or sunset.

Without wind or water, Mercury's craters will never wear away.

MAKING CRATERS

Try making your own crater landscape. You will need a washing-up bowl, flour, and objects of different shapes and sizes, such as a ball, a marble, or a stone. These objects will be your "asteroids."



1. Pour some flour into a bowl, spread it out evenly, and smooth down the surface with a spoon. The flour should be about 2 inches (5 cm) deep. This will be your "landscape."

2. Place the bowl on some newspaper on the floor. Drop your asteroids onto your landscape.

3. See how different-sized asteroids make different-sized craters. Bigger asteroids make wider and deeper craters. Try throwing the asteroids at different speeds. The faster they travel, the more impact they have on the landscape.

It might be best to do this outside!

